homelands. Their language is today classified as a Malayalamoid sub-group, with no clear identity of its own.

The Kanikkars' ancestors were most probably among the many 'first Indians' who entered India over the course of multiple eastward migrations extending over many thousands of years.[11] Their prime concerns would have altered very little over that extended period: survival, food and the fertility of both themselves and those elements of their surroundings that kept them fed. Fertility is crucial to the survival of the tribe, so the earliest representations of the human form in modelled clay took the form of fecund women with exaggerated female parts. These concerns would have been coupled with fear of the known, such as snakes, tigers and other mortal enemies, and even greater fear of the unknown, in the form of ghosts, evil spirits and the ancestral dead. This gave rise to various forms of pantheism, animism or totemism, all involving worship or propitiation through offerings and sacrifices of the elemental forces present in nature, such as animal-spirits, tree-spirits and water-spirits. This is the core religion of the hunter-gatherer.

Today most of the Kanikkar follow identifiably Hindu religious customs but a century ago they still had their own forest deities, worshipped at jungle gatherings beside streams. These were presided over by the tribe's shaman, chosen not by heredity but by his or even her special ability 'to invoke the deity and who sometimes becomes inspired and gives expression to oracular utterances'. Their rituals involved simple offerings, including the sacrifice of a cock, and a great deal of drumming, chanting and dancing which culminated in the participants becoming possessed and falling into trances. The Kanikkar buried rather than cremated their dead, and to ensure that their spirits could not return to harm the living, they planted a coconut palm over their graves.